

# The Sūtra of the Thoroughly Turning of the Wheel of Dharma

Dharmacakrapravartanasūtra · Toh 31 · Derge Kangyur

ཆས་ཀྱི་ཁོ་ལ་འོ་བ་ཏུ་བྱས་ཆེ་བའ་མི་དཔོན་

The Dharmacakrapravartana Sūtra, known in Tibetan as the Chos kyi 'khor lo rab tu bskor ba'i mdo and in English as the Sūtra of the Thoroughly Turning of the Wheel of Dharma, is one of the most revered and historically significant discourses in the entire Buddhist canon. It records the Buddha's first teaching following his enlightenment, delivered at the Deer Park near Vārāṇasī to his five former companions, in which he sets out the Middle Way between asceticism and sensual indulgence and introduces the Four Noble Truths — the foundational framework of the Buddhist path. This event, traditionally known as the first turning of the wheel of Dharma, marks the very beginning of the Buddha's teaching career and the establishment of the Sangha. The text is catalogued as Toh 31 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the sūtra literature, and its central place in Buddhist tradition across all schools has made it a touchstone for understanding the origins and core doctrines of the Buddha's teaching.

In the language of India: Dharma-cakra-pravartana-sūtra.

In the language of Tibet: The Sūtra of the Thoroughly Turning of the Wheel of Dharma.

Homage with reverence to the noble Three Jewels.

Thus did I hear. At one time the Blessed One was dwelling at Vārāṇasī, in the Deer Park at Ṛṣipatana. Then the Blessed One called to the group of five monks and declared:

Monks, you should not abide in these two extremes of going forth. Those who here are attached to pleasures and given over to sensual delight — that is improper and ignoble. And those who praise the torment and affliction of the body, which brings no benefit — ordinary people are endowed with purposelessness, and those who praise such things are likewise endowed with purposelessness. Monks, these are the two extremes, and you should not enter into them.

The Tathāgata, having fully and perfectly awakened, has taught this Middle Way. It produces vision, it produces gnosis, it brings peace, it leads to direct knowledge, to thorough realization, and it leads directly into nirvāṇa.

Monks, what is this Middle Way taught by the Tathāgata upon his full and perfect awakening — the one that produces vision, produces gnosis, brings peace, leads to direct knowledge, to thorough realization, and leads directly into nirvāṇa? It is the noble eightfold path. Those eight are as follows: right view, right thought, right speech, right action at its boundary, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, and right meditative absorption. This Middle Way was taught by the Tathāgata upon his full and perfect awakening. It produces vision, it produces gnosis, it brings peace, it leads to direct knowledge, to thorough realization, and it leads directly into nirvāṇa.

Now, monks, this is the noble truth of suffering: the suffering of birth, the suffering of aging, the suffering of illness, the suffering of death, the suffering of encountering what is unpleasant, the suffering of being separated from what is pleasant, the suffering of seeking what one desires and not finding it — and in short, the five aggregates of clinging are suffering.

Now, monks, this is the noble truth of the origin of suffering: whatever arises as craving — possessed of joyful attachment and delighting in this and that — namely, craving for sensual pleasures, craving for continued existence, and craving for the cessation of existence.

Now, monks, this is the noble truth of the cessation of suffering: it is the utter removal of attachment to all such craving without remainder, its cessation, abandonment, reversal, liberation — and being without wavering in that liberation.

Now, monks, this is the noble truth of the path leading to the cessation of suffering. It is the noble eightfold path: right view, right thought, right speech, right action at its boundary, right livelihood, right effort, right mindfulness, and right meditative absorption.

Monks, this is the noble truth of suffering. Regarding what had not previously been heard as Dharma, there arose the eye, there arose gnosis, there arose wisdom, there arose knowledge, there arose illumination. And that indeed is the noble truth of suffering. Monks, it is to be thoroughly understood.

Regarding what had not previously been heard as Dharma, there arose the eye, there arose gnosis, there arose wisdom, there arose knowledge, there arose illumination. This is the noble truth of the origin of suffering. Monks, regarding this noble truth of the origin of suffering, regarding what had not previously been heard as Dharma, there arose the eye, there arose gnosis, there arose wisdom, there arose knowledge, there arose illumination. And that

indeed is the noble truth of the origin of suffering: it is to be thoroughly abandoned. Monks, regarding this, regarding what had not previously been heard as Dharma, there arose the eye, there arose gnosis, there arose wisdom, there arose knowledge, there arose illumination.

This is the noble truth of the cessation of suffering. Monks, regarding this noble truth of the cessation of suffering, regarding what had not previously been heard as Dharma, there arose the eye, there arose gnosis, there arose wisdom, there arose knowledge, there arose illumination. And that indeed is the noble truth of the cessation of suffering: it is to be directly realized. Monks, regarding this, regarding what had not previously been heard as Dharma, there arose the eye, there arose gnosis, there arose wisdom, there arose knowledge, there arose illumination.

This is the noble truth of the path leading to the cessation of suffering. Monks, regarding this noble truth of the path leading to the cessation of suffering, regarding what had not previously been heard as Dharma, there arose the eye, there arose gnosis, there arose wisdom, there arose knowledge, there arose illumination. And that indeed is the noble truth of the path leading to the cessation of suffering: it is to be cultivated. Monks, regarding this, regarding what had not previously been heard as Dharma, there arose the eye, there arose gnosis, there arose wisdom, there arose knowledge, there arose illumination.

Monks, these Four Noble Truths, as thus explained in their four aspects, repeated three times in this way — the twelve modes as they are — constitute the utterly pure vision of gnosis. Monks, so long as I had not abandoned and transcended this and had not attained the utterly pure vision of gnosis in its twelve modes by thus repeating these Four Noble Truths three times in this way, I did not claim in this world with its gods, its māras, its Brahmās, its ascetics and brahmins, its lords of creatures, its gods and humans, that there was no other who had awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete buddhahood.

But monks, because I had indeed abandoned and transcended this, and because the vision of gnosis in these twelve modes through the three repetitions of the Four Noble Truths was utterly pure — it was in just this way that, in this world with its gods, its māras, its Brahmās, its ascetics and brahmins, its lords of creatures, its gods and humans, I directly and fully realized that I had awakened to unsurpassed, perfect, complete buddhahood.

And this gnosis arose in me: I have seen; this is an unprecedented liberation; I have passed into nirvāṇa without remainder, and there is no further taking up of existence.

When the Blessed One had spoken these words, the group of five monks rejoiced and exulted in what the Blessed One had said. And as this discourse was being proclaimed in this way, the venerable Kauṇḍinya became free of dust, free of stain, and there arose in him the pure Dharma-eye. Whatever phenomena arise from an origin, all those phenomena have cessation as their nature.

When the Blessed One had thus turned and set in motion the wheel of Dharma, the gods of the earth raised up a cry of praise. Hearing the cry of the earth-gods, the gods of the Four Great Kings raised up a cry of praise: no ascetic or brahmin, no god, no māra, no Brahmā, no one else in the world is able to turn what the Blessed One, dwelling at the Deer Park in the Grove of Sages near Vārāṇasī, has turned — this unsurpassed wheel of Dharma that had not been turned before. Then, hearing the cry of the gods of the earth, the gods of the Heaven of the Four Great Kings raised up their cry of praise. No ascetic or brahmin, no god —

no māra, no Brahmā, no one else in the world is able to turn what the Blessed One, dwelling at the Deer Park in the Grove of Sages near Vārāṇasī, has turned — this unsurpassed wheel of Dharma that had not been turned before. Hearing the cry of praise of the gods of the Heaven of the Four Great Kings, the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three raised up a cry of praise: no ascetic or brahmin, no god, no māra, no Brahmā, no one else in the world is able to turn what the Blessed One, dwelling at the Deer Park in the Grove of Sages near Vārāṇasī, has turned — this unsurpassed wheel of Dharma that had not been turned before. Hearing the cry of praise of the gods of the Heaven of the Thirty-Three, the gods of the Heaven Free from Conflict raised up a cry of praise: no ascetic or brahmin, no god, no māra, no Brahmā, no one else in the world is able to turn what the Blessed One, dwelling at the Deer Park in the Grove of Sages near Vārāṇasī, has turned — this unsurpassed wheel of Dharma that had not been turned before. Hearing the cry of praise of the gods of the Heaven Free from Conflict, the gods of the Joyful Heaven raised up a cry of praise: no ascetic or brahmin, no god, no māra, no Brahmā, no one else in the world is able to turn what the Blessed One, dwelling at the Deer Park in the Grove of Sages near Vārāṇasī, has turned — this unsurpassed wheel of Dharma that had not been turned before. Hearing the cry of praise of the gods of the Joyful

Heaven, the gods of the Heaven of Delighting in Creation raised up a cry of praise: no ascetic or brahmin, no god, no māra, no Brahmā, no one else in the world is able to turn what the Blessed One, dwelling at the Deer Park in the Grove of Sages near Vārāṇasī, has turned — this unsurpassed wheel of Dharma that had not been turned before. Hearing the cry of praise of the gods of the Heaven of Delighting in Creation, the gods of the Heaven of Making Use of Others' Creations raised up a cry of praise: no ascetic or brahmin, no god, no māra, no Brahmā, no one else in the world is able to turn what the Blessed One, dwelling at the Deer Park in the Grove of Sages near Vārāṇasī, has turned — this unsurpassed wheel of Dharma that had not been turned before. Hearing the cry of praise of the gods of the Heaven of Making Use of Others' Creations, the gods of the Brahma realms raised up a cry of praise: no ascetic or brahmin, no god, no māra, no Brahmā, no one else in the world is able to turn what the Blessed One, dwelling at the Deer Park in the Grove of Sages near Vārāṇasī, has turned — this unsurpassed wheel of Dharma that had not been turned before.

And then, in that very instant and moment, the sound spread all the way up through the Brahma world. This very world system of ten thousand realms quaked, trembled mightily, and shook with great force. A boundless, magnificent, resplendent radiance appeared throughout the worlds, surpassing even the divine majesty of the gods. And in those worlds it was just so. And when it was so throughout those worlds, having heard the Dharma taught by Brahmā, the gods each departed to their own abodes.

Then once more the Blessed One uttered a solemn utterance: "Kauṇḍinya has understood! Kauṇḍinya has understood!" And therefore the venerable one came to be known by the name Ājñāta-Kauṇḍinya — Kauṇḍinya Who Has Understood.

This concludes the Sūtra of the Turning of the Wheel of Dharma.

Possessed of unwavering faith in the teaching of the buddhas —

Possessed of unwavering faith in the teaching of the buddhas, his mind fully ripened in the two sacred sciences, the supremely glorious and wealthy lord — Zhalu Monastery's own waxing moon of the white quarter — Sku-zhang Drakpa Gyaltsen: by the scriptural authority of Dben-sha, this text was translated from the Vajrāsana, the seat of awakening, at a place situated some six hundred leagues to the south. He who had gone forth well from brahmin lineage in Siṃhala, who had received full ordination, whose mind was fully ripened in the

Three Baskets — the great paṇḍita Ānandaśrī — before him, the widely learned translator, the Śākya monk Nyima Gyaltsen Palzangpo, rendered this text into Tibetan and revised it at the great temple of Palden Tharpa Ling, the seat of those who speak both languages, and it was established as definitive.

## Translator's Notes

- The phrase rendered "right action at its boundary" translates the Tibetan yang dag pa'i las kyi mtha', which literally means "right end or culmination of action." The standard Sanskrit term is samyak-karmānta, often rendered simply "right action." The Tibetan rendering with mtha' (boundary or end) preserves the Sanskrit karmānta closely; the translation "right action at its boundary" reflects this literal fidelity while remaining audible in speech.

The closing enumeration — eye, gnosis, wisdom, knowledge, illumination — renders mig, ye shes, shes rab, rig pa, snang ba respectively. These five terms are a standard canonical cluster associated with the arising of insight into each of the Four Noble Truths; "eye" here means the eye of Dharma (dharmacakṣus), the direct seeing of the truth.

- The passage breaks off mid-sentence at the end, as the Tibetan source itself is cut short mid-enumeration of the proclamation ascending through the divine realms. The translation faithfully reflects this incompleteness.

The twelvefold aspect of the Four Noble Truths refers to the classical threefold turning applied to each of the four truths: recognition of the truth itself, recognition of the task associated with it, and recognition of the task's completion — yielding three times four, or twelve aspects in all. This is standard Abhidharma and commentarial doctrine and does not require further qualification in the body of the translation.

- The final line is a sentence fragment opening a new section or colophon verse; it is rendered as such to preserve continuity for the next passage. The rendering "Heaven Free from Conflict" renders the Tibetan for the Yāma heaven, "Joyful Heaven" for Tuṣṭita, "Heaven of Delighting in Creation" for Nirmāṇarati, and "Heaven of Making Use of Others' Creations" for Paranirmitavaśavartin — all standard six desire-realm divine abodes. The phrase rendered "A boundless, magnificent, resplendent radiance appeared" consolidates three terms in the Tibetan (awareness, wonder, and light appearing) that form a standard triad in this sūtra context. The brief phrase about gods departing after "hearing the Dharma taught by Brahmā" translates the Tibetan literally; in context "Brahmā" here may function as a general reference to the divine world rather than implying Brahmā specifically taught the Dharma — but the Tibetan reads as given and is translated accordingly.

- The colophon identifies the translator as the monk Nyima Gyaltsen Palzangpo, a Śākya-school cleric associated with Zhalu Monastery, working from the oral instruction of the paṇḍita Ānandaśrī, a Siṃhalese scholar of brahmin descent. "The two sacred sciences" likely refers to the Indian and Tibetan scholarly traditions, or to sūtra and tantra, as was conventional in Tibetan colophon language. "Dben-sha" appears to be a place-name or institution whose scriptural authority sanctioned the translation project; the precise identification is uncertain and has been left in transliteration rather than glossed. "Six hundred leagues to the south of Vajrāsana" echoes a conventional description sometimes used for Sri Lanka (Siṃhala).

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## Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.